

sh Ambani's Viacom18 snagged the digital streaming rights of the IPL for 2023-27 for ₹23,758 crore. Viacom18 has also landed an investment of ₹13,500-crore led by media veterans James Murdoch and Uday Shankar, heating up the competition in the space. Rakshit says the plan now is to focus on originals, films, sports, short form content and interactives. "We need to dial that up to the next level, and do it better than others."

Massy advertising-based video on demand (AVOD) OTT platform MX Player has a mix of original shows such as the Bobby Deol starrer *Aashram*, and *Bhaukaal*, along with a host of licensing deals with firms with large content libraries such as Shemaroo to offer their audience a wide variety of content. "Certainly, original content investment is what we are focussing on," says Karan Bedi, the CEO of MX Player.

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MEANWHILE IN THE SOUTH, actor Allu Arjun-backed Telugu OTT platform aha plans to quadruple its user base to at least 8 million by getting into non-Hindi languages. It forayed into Tamil originals in April and plans to launch Malayalam next year, and two more languages thereafter. Also in the works are an AVOD service, gaming and live news content for the Telugu audience. "For the 100 per cent local ecosystem, we are like the super app. You will get news, gaming, AVOD, SVOD and we'll keep expanding [into other] languages," says aha's CEO, Ajit Thakur.

SVF Entertainment-promoted Bengali OTT player hoichoi has continued to bet on new original shows or movies every week, including bigger shows such as *Feludar Goyendagiri*. "That has built a lot of trust with the audience. If there are gaps, the audience loses patience and doesn't want to renew subscriptions. We are consistently seeing numbers which are higher than even the lockdown numbers," says hoichoi's Co-founder, Vishnu Mohta.

If good content is the magnet that OTTs are betting on to attract viewers, technology is the coating that will make



"India is not a fragmented OTT market. For SonyLIV, growth will come from the south and the demographics of women and young adults"

DANISH KHAN

HEAD - SONYLIV,
SONY ENTERTAINMENT
TELEVISION
AND STUDIO NEXT



"We work with content owners who don't have reach on their own, to ensure their content is visible, gets consumed and share that revenue in different models"

KARAN BEDI

CEO, MX PLAYER

them stick, especially as people are on the move again. But it's also where the Indian apps lag behind global giants Netflix and Amazon Prime Video. The lack of a smooth viewing experience is a barrier for many subscribers, says consultancy Ormax Media's Founder and CEO, Shailesh Kapoor. "A lot of apps still have issues on how the content plays. If you come back two days later, can you start from where you left? You can't be spending crores on content and giving sub-optimal user experience."

It's an expensive and time-consuming endeavour, but the streamers are pulling up their socks to get it right. Disney+ Hotstar recently launched Dolby 5.1 surround sound on its platform to enhance its 'cricketainment' offering, says Sidd Mantri, Head of Product of Developing Markets at Disney Streaming. Apps like SonyLIV and aha are also introducing tech such as 4K viewing and Dolby sound on their apps. "Our tech and analytics budget is almost similar to our marketing budget," says aha's Thakur.

Now, it's important that OTT platforms play content well, both on TV and mobile devices. "OTT is no more a mobile phenomenon post-Covid-19," says Thakur. Voot's Rakshit believes that better user experience boosts viewership by 100 per cent, if not more. "It's about viewers being able to discover exactly what they want to watch... The outside structure is very similar for all OTTs. The rules that define how you go from one place to another in the app [without getting lost] is where versatility comes in." The platform is focussing on improving live streaming of sports and reducing latency, while MX Player has upgraded its video compression technology to halve data usage. "Data cost in India is far cheaper than anywhere else in the world. People are still very conscious of how much they use. We invest a lot of time and money in creating high compression. People can consume more content with the same amount of data," says Bedi of MX Player.